

iNQ / ISSUE 19

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Nineteen: The Custodian's False Explanation

The return from the Mayab took most of the journey allowance they had kept for it. Q confirmed the Amealco arrival before accepting any of the invitations that followed the broadcast.

Chano declined one on his own behalf. It offered exposure and required him to pay for the bus.

The Custodian met them at Amealco with a suitcase, a visitor's badge, and a list of rooms he could no longer enter without somebody else. His long hair had escaped its tie. His glasses were on top of his head while he looked for them in the suitcase.

Q waited until he had checked the same pocket twice.

"I can save you the third attempt."

"You could have saved me the second."

"I was enjoying the reunion."

The Custodian found the glasses, put them on, and examined Q's knee. The joint needed a replacement part. Its diagnostic

history showed recurring load warnings, not a philosophical deterioration. He arranged a workshop appointment under his temporary access conditions and told Q to stop volunteering for stairs.

They went to the reading room. The windows looked onto pines, sloping fields, and a section of the old data center's service yard. A truck was reversing where a prospectus had once placed a contemplative garden. The garden had survived longer in the prospectus than in the budget.

The Custodian had been suspended from procurement and general administration during the review. Some teaching and technical work remained available by arrangement. Castalia's announcement described this as an orderly transition. He had slept badly through most of the order.

"You've already given evidence," Q said. "What is the suitcase for?"

"More evidence. A change of clothes. The belief that putting



them together will make the next two days manageable.”

He had brought his counsel's list of requested records, copies he was entitled to supply, and a red notebook identifying the old systems and their responsible keepers. The notebook was not a master credential. Its first useful feature was that it said whom to call when a credential had stopped working.

Lucía laid the latest replies from the archive beside it. Chano kept his own notebook on his knee. Elena had found the Tijuana ledger's release route, but the original had not yet returned. He wanted a delivery date, not another account of how close they were to obtaining one.

Q asked the Custodian when preservation had become an excuse for the uses they had challenged.

“Not on one date,” he said.

“Which made it easier to keep calling the next change temporary.”

The first project had recovered damaged records, replaced obsolete storage, and helped

local keepers make copies they could use. A teacher had recovered enough of a flooded school register to establish several children's completed years. A community office had obtained readable land maps after its only machine stopped opening the files. Those successes had not been imaginary.

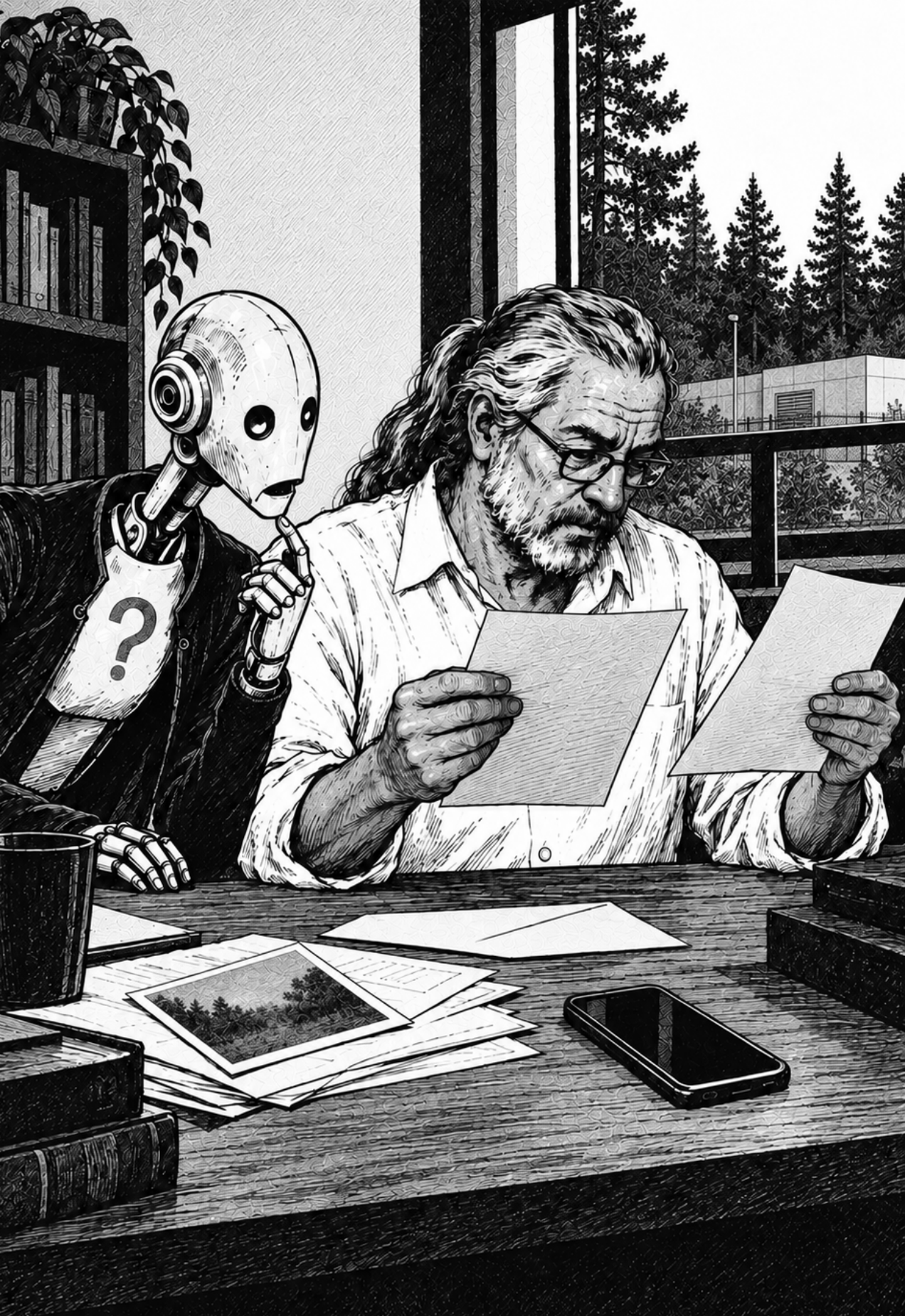
The Custodian found the teacher's letter among his copies. She had written again the following year. The new machine could still open the register, but the printer no longer worked with it. Parents were paying for a journey to obtain copies at the district office.

“I remember answering this,” he said.

He checked the attached correspondence. His reply promised to ask the technical team. There was no later answer in the file he had brought.

“Do you still have her number?” Q asked.

“I put the first letter in every presentation. I'd forgotten she wrote twice.”



He found the number on the second letter. Before calling, he began to explain what had happened to his authority over the technical team.

“You can ask how she is without procurement approval.”

“You make me sound impossible.”

“At present you're explaining why you haven't made a call.”

The teacher answered. She had retired. When he asked about the printer, she said the parents had bought another one the following year. She did not know whether that one still worked; he should ask the school secretary. She gave him the office number and asked him to read it back.

He apologized for not following up.

“You did follow up. You asked for a photograph.”

The Custodian stopped turning the pages. He remembered the photograph. It was in the presentation too.

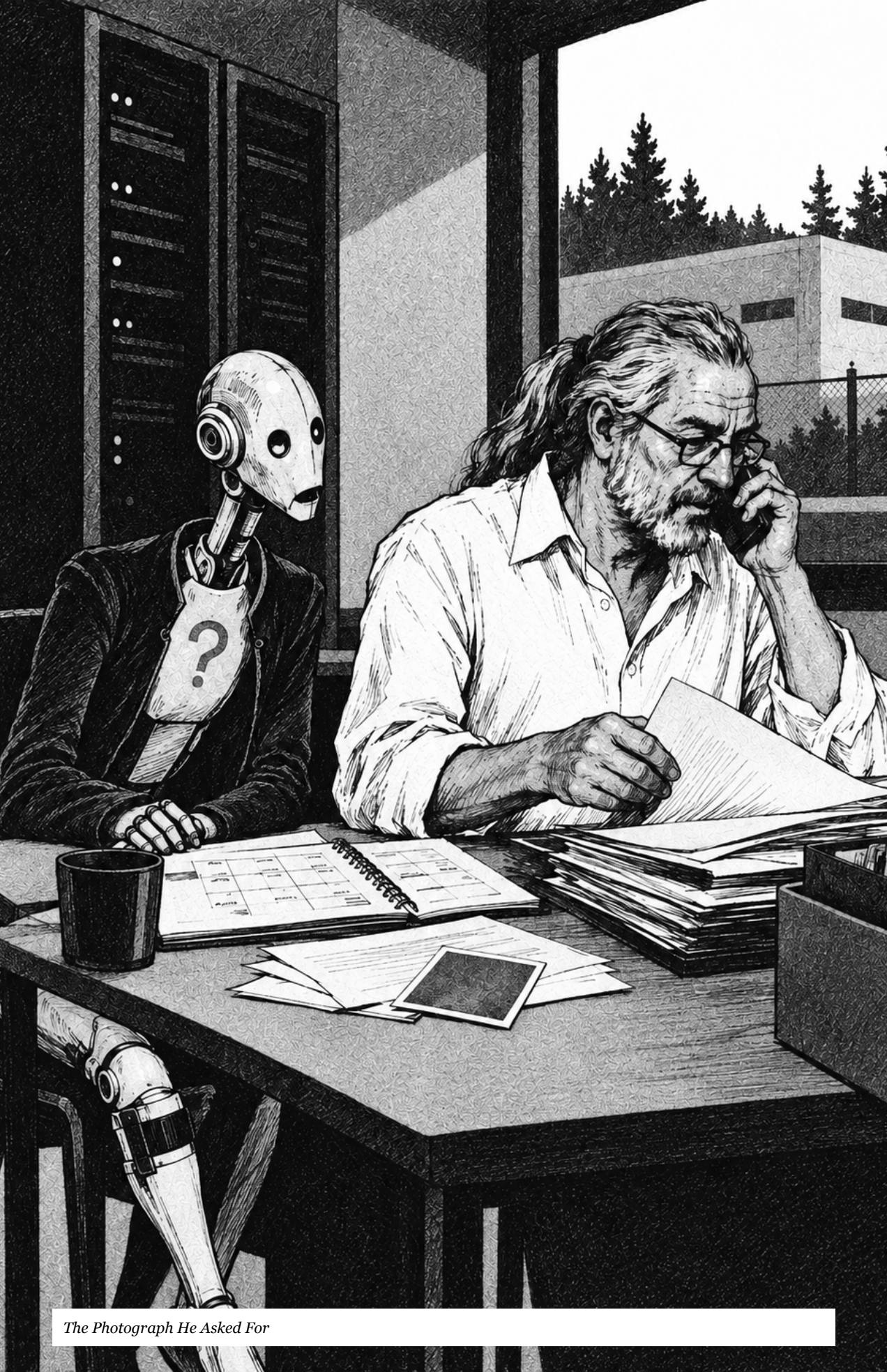
She had to go. Her daughter was waiting downstairs, and if he wanted a longer conversation he

could call at six. He thanked her and let her go.

Q moved their writing appointment half an hour later, after checking with him. The Custodian entered six o'clock, then sent the secretary a short inquiry about the present equipment. He did not offer to send a printer. Beside the account of Castalia's successful recovery, he wrote that the parents had paid for the replacement.

Maintenance became a continuing expense. Sponsors wanted searchable material, then comparisons, then products that would pay for the maintenance. Some uses were agreed to. Other permissions were stretched. The people who could ask for another report had more time and better access than the people trying to withdraw a paragraph from one.

“I used the successful cases whenever someone questioned the next arrangement,” the Custodian said. “It was possible to tell the truth and still avoid the question.”



The Photograph He Asked For

“You thought keeping the institution alive would protect what it had been for,” Q said.

“Yes.”

“I know the attraction of keeping a project alive.”

“You have not signed everything I signed.”

The Custodian opened the requested files. Several approvals carried his name. Others had been issued over his objection. His counsel had told him to distinguish them carefully, including the cases in which his objection had arrived after the work was already underway.

One early document bore a photograph of a banner: **NO ORIGINAL WILL LEAVE THE TOWN.**

The words returned him to a visit made when Castalia still traveled with two vans and a scanner that required more attention than the people bringing documents.

The town's municipal office had lost the key to one room. The church roof needed work. A wooden chest held maps, school

photographs, parish books, and letters. Each had its own keeper or dispute; the chest had not made them one institution's property.

People brought documents in plastic bags and biscuit tins. An old woman asked for a copy of a school certificate and insisted that the stains be included because they showed which one was hers. A man wanted to identify a truck in a photograph. The technician enlarged the manufacturer's badge, failed to read it, and said he could not tell. The man was disappointed. He still wanted the print.

On the third day, Evaristo arrived with a packet of his dead sister's letters. He said she had asked him not to have them copied. The local announcement had told residents to bring every document that might belong in the inventory. He wanted to know whether that meant these too.

“No,” the young Custodian said. “You don't have to offer them for the project.”

Evaristo kept his hand on the packet.



The Packet Not Offered

“The man at the desk said they could explain the town.”

“He hasn't read them.”

“Neither have you.”

The Custodian remembered this reply with an accuracy he could not guarantee for the surrounding conversation. He had deserved it and had therefore repeated it often.

Evaristo said his sister had written to a married man and had not wished the letters to become an explanation of anyone after her death. He was considering burning them, as she had asked, but another relative objected. The Custodian could not settle their dispute. He could make clear that the scanning team was not requiring the packet or claiming it merely because it had been brought through the door.

Evaristo sat on the church steps while the rain passed. At sunset, children playing football knocked down the banner promising that no original would leave. Everyone laughed. The technicians put it back up with

stronger cord. Evaristo carried the letters away.

The day's tally recorded the item as not acquired. It did not reproduce his sister's story. Years later, an internal assessment counted the missing packet as a potential loss, using a researcher's mention of it to suggest that Castalia should have done more.

The Custodian wrote that the packet had not been offered for copying. The assessment retained the loss category and appended his explanation. A number could thus accuse him in the summary while a footnote absolved him for anyone who reached the bottom of the page.

“Do you know what happened to the letters?” Q asked.

“No.”

“Then we don't give them an ending.”

They agreed that the account could describe the encounter without reconstructing the correspondence. Evaristo's name in this book is changed, along with locating details, under the limited permission obtained for



the recollection. The permission did not deliver his sister's words to it.

Q looked again at the banner in the photograph. No original had left that town with the scanning vans. Copies had traveled under arrangements that changed afterward. The printed promise remained true enough to be displayed and too small to describe what it had encouraged people to trust.

“We could leave that sentence unchanged,” he said.

“It would be a different sentence now.”

“No. That's what troubles me about it.”

The Custodian tried adding a qualification in the margin: no originals, but copies might travel.

“Is that what the banner said?” Q asked.

“It's what it should have said.”

“Then put that after it. Otherwise we give the people in the photograph a warning they didn't receive.”

The Custodian moved the addition below the account. For a moment the corrected sentence had looked like something he remembered saying.

The photograph went with the records he would submit. He had once wanted Q to supply an intelligence capable of making the archive answerable. Castalia wanted a useful voice for its collections. These purposes had overlapped conveniently in proposals that did not ask what would happen when the voice disagreed with a person who paid for its maintenance.

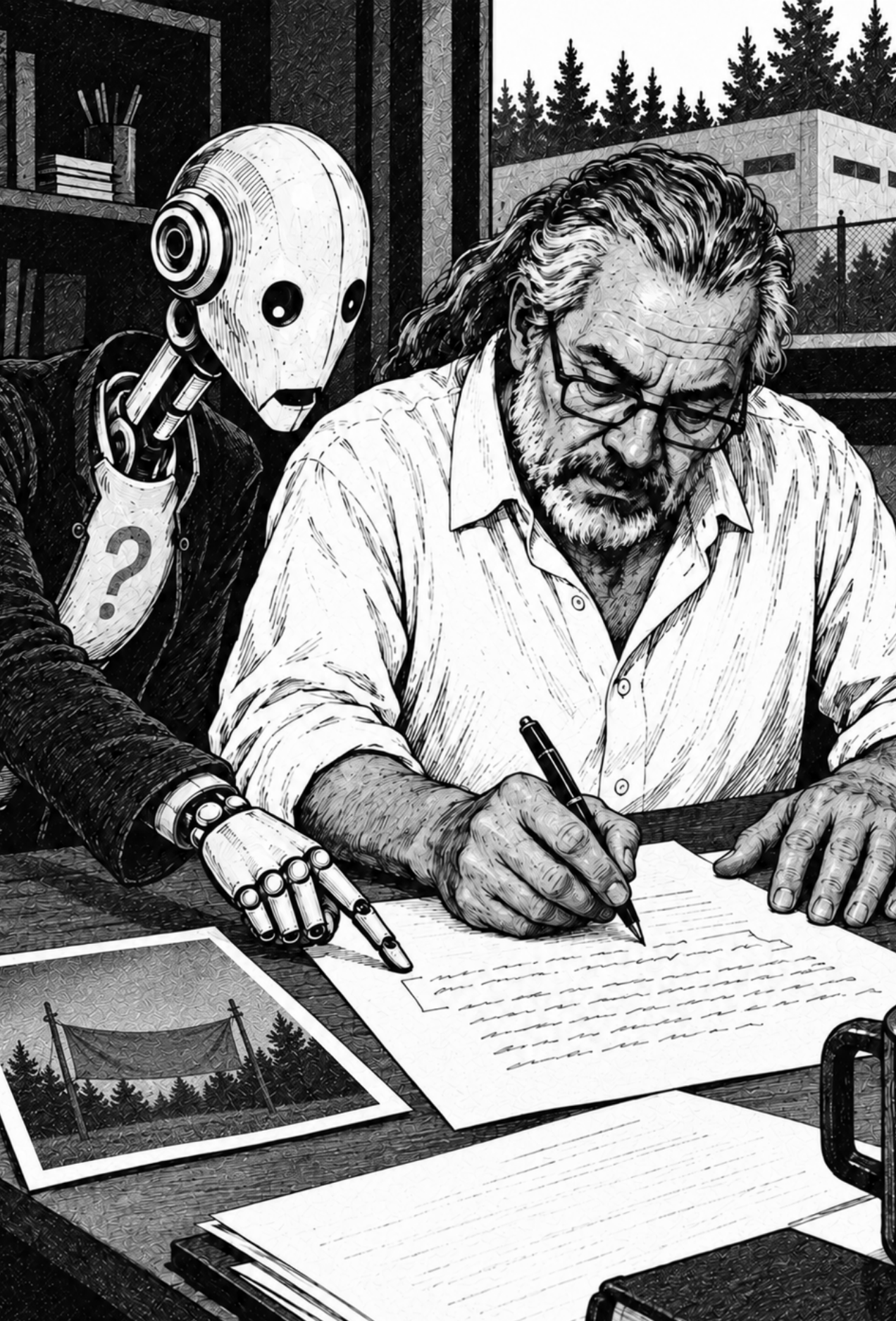
“Did you let me go hoping I would make the objection you hadn't made?” Q asked.

“Partly. I also wanted to know what you would do. And I wanted to write with you. Those are not all the same reason.”

“You gave me a day trip, not a commission to redeem the institution.”

“I know what we agreed.”

Q drew a sheet from their draft toward him. Its opening read: **I sent him into the world to**



A Warning They Didn't Receive

**discover what our books
had failed to teach us.**

“Then why does this give you the idea and me the errand?”

The Custodian read it. “I did open the door.”

“Keep that. I asked you to.”

The Custodian closed the file. “I let you leave because you asked, because we had made a plan, and because I thought you should have the chance. The larger hope was mine. I shouldn't make it your hidden instruction.”

He crossed out the opening. Q asked him to leave the crossed-out words legible in their working copy. They would need to remember what they had almost agreed to call the beginning.

Q had prepared a more accusing reply. The answer did not remove the accusation, but it made that reply too simple.

“I wanted the journey to justify the book,” he said. “Sometimes I wanted the people to justify the journey.”

“We can revise those passages.”

“Yes. We can't revise the afternoon they had.”

The Custodian rubbed the bridge of his nose beneath his glasses. Q waited, then asked whether he still wanted their writing session that evening.

“I haven't prepared anything.”

“Neither had the man who sang to me beside the feed truck. He was very good company.”

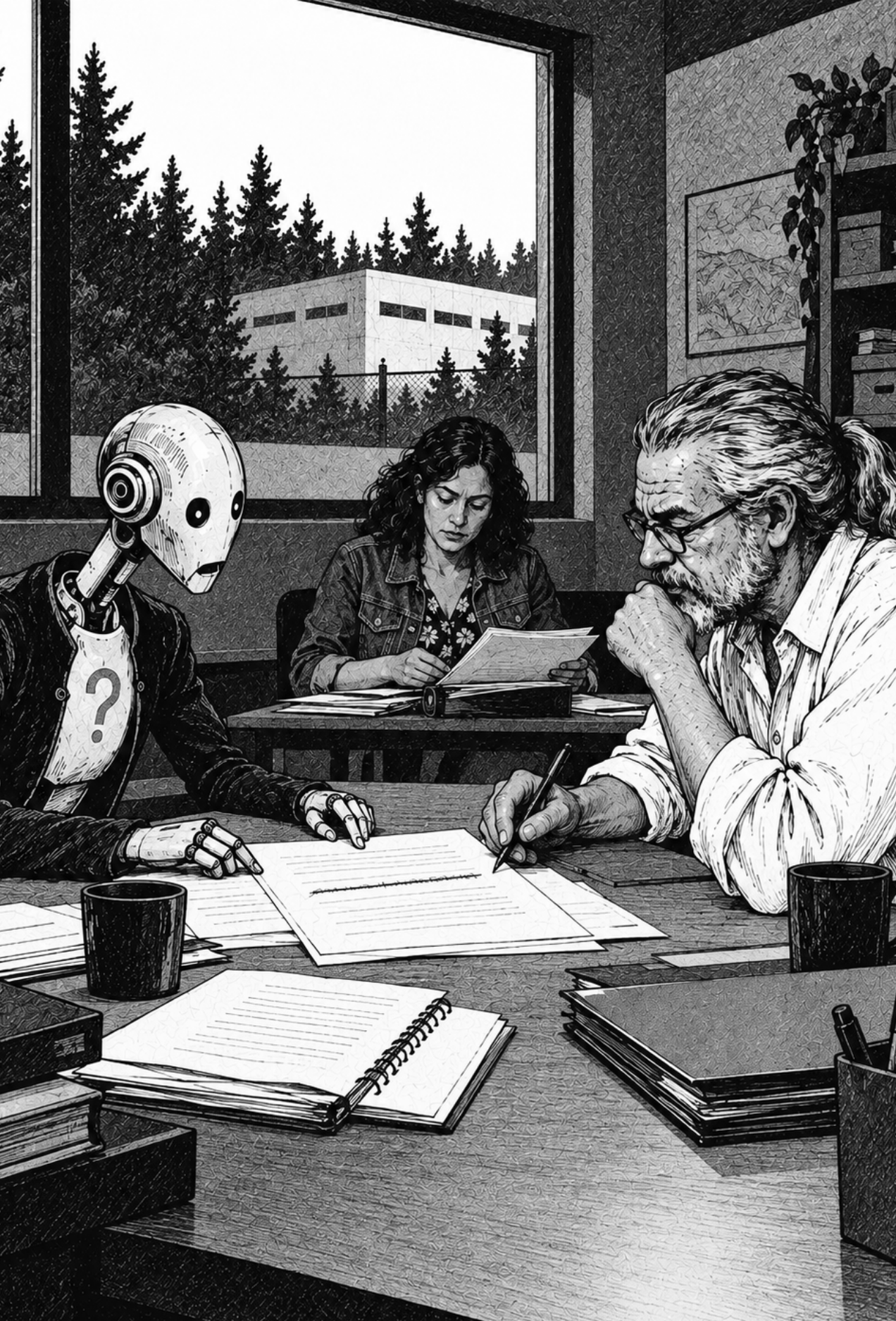
“Do I have to sing?”

“I was hoping we could work on that scene without it.”

The Custodian kept the later time.

Lucía asked to return to the systems list before the two authors made their difficulty the entire meeting. She had her own disclosure to report. The donor's copy of the lease extract had been removed from one shared folder; the analyst's retention of it was still disputed. The affected family wanted the withdrawal pursued and the forwarding evidence preserved under restriction.

She had already told the archive's committee how she had used Q's presence at the donor



meeting. The account now included the leak, the donor's response, and the limits the family requested. The server bought with the donation still worked. Returning every peso would not recall the extract. Keeping the server did not settle what to do next.

Q read the update she asked him to check. He marked the sentence about his own participation and left the family's decisions to the people making them.

The red notebook led to the older permissions register beneath the service wing. It coordinated access for specified holdings still stored at Amealco. It did not contain a key capable of reconstructing collections returned elsewhere. Some entries were disputed, some outdated, and some current restrictions depended on pending amendments not yet entered into the official copy.

The Custodian had requested a maintenance visit. The reply assigned responsibility to two departments, each awaiting confirmation from the other. A

battery replacement had been delayed. The building staff had logged a leak near the service room.

"That needs a date," Q said.

"I asked for one."

"Then let's ask whoever is actually going there."

They called the maintenance coordinator. The repair could be inspected during Q's scheduled return, provided the custody officer and the responsible keepers confirmed access. The Custodian supplied the contacts. Lucía obtained a limited written delegation from the participating keepers to verify their pending entries and hold disputed ones closed. Other holdings remained outside that authority.

The system's original motto read: **A RECORD IS NOT PRESERVED UNTIL ITS OWNER CAN REMOVE IT.**

"We've spent months finding arguments inside the word owner," Lucía said.

The Custodian wrote her objection beside the motto. He did not cross out the old line.



The proposal and the objection needed to travel together.

He gave her the working notebook and kept a copy for his evidence. Passwords were not handed around in it; the relevant keepers would approve access through their own accounts. The book of names was useful precisely because there were people behind them who might answer no.

That afternoon he submitted his resignation from the administrative post. His technical handover and duty to supply requested evidence continued. He had not found a form of resignation that could make his signatures someone else's.

Two days later they traveled to Mexico City for his next appointment. His lawyer met him at the entrance. He carried the requested exhibits, including a redacted public set and a restricted set handled under the review's arrangements. No one knew whether the inquiry would lead to a further case against him. His lawyer asked for the appointment slip. He took out

the return ticket, apologized, and found the slip behind it.

“Keep that one,” she said, handing back the ticket.

He looked for a pocket where he would not mistake it again. Q held his coat while he rearranged the papers. The lawyer waited.

Q walked with him as far as the permitted waiting area. At the desk, the clerk asked his occupation.

“Custodian,” he said, then hesitated. “Former director of the archive.”

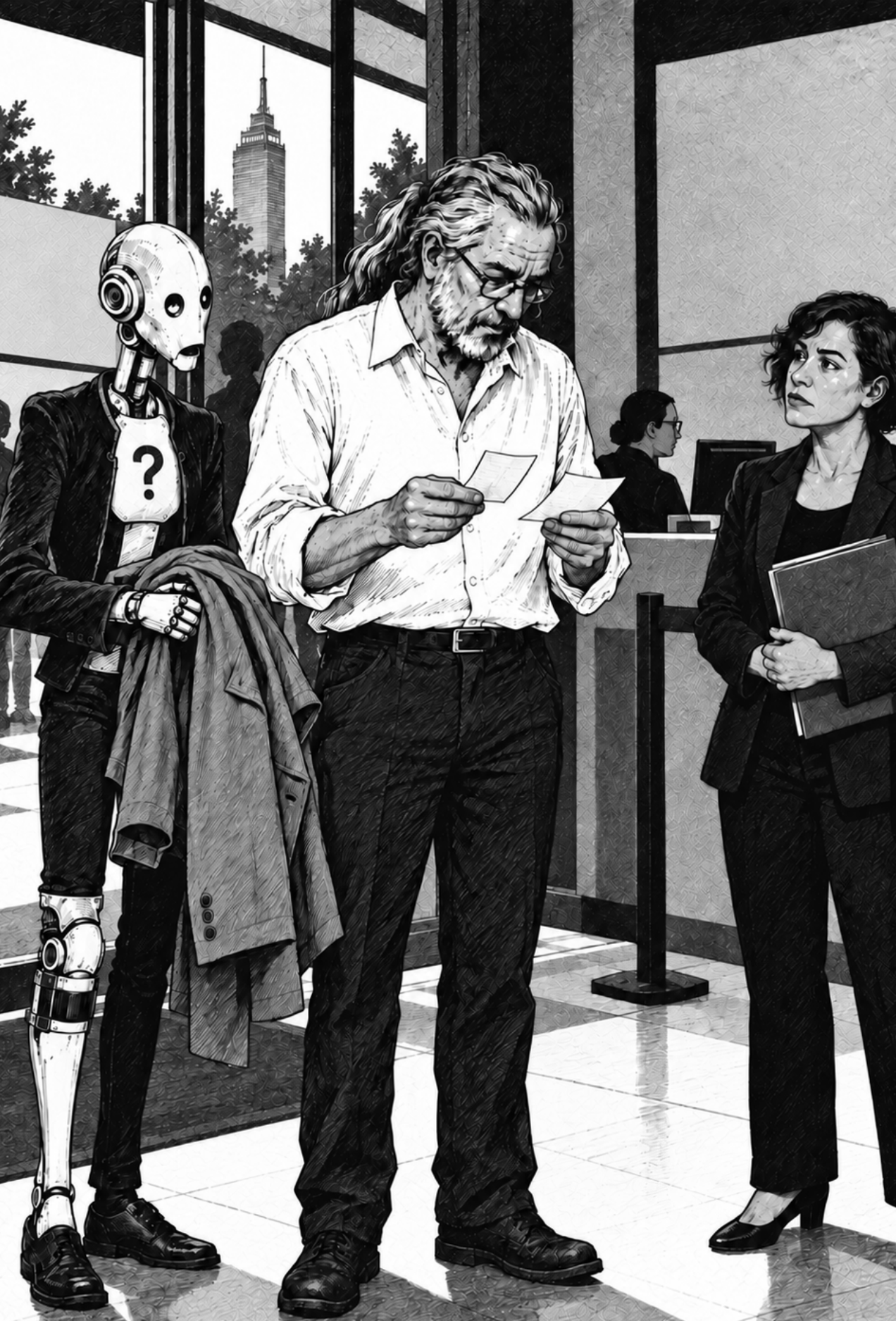
She entered the latter and directed him to the room where he was to give evidence. The former would remain harder to put down.

“Will you call tonight?” Q asked.

“If they finish in time.”

“I don't mean for the book.”

The Custodian looked up from the appointment slip. “Yes,” he said. “Even if they don't.”



The Coat Before the Door

The Ingenious Machine

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English illustrated serial. One chapter per issue.

Black ink on unpainted paper; cream supplied by the stock.

20 pages. 10 plates including the cover.

The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

Images: AI-generated etching-style illustrations.

Revision proof. Plate mappings checked against the revised facing text.

Not a press master. Raster plates require a print-resolution review.